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Courtesy of John Di Leonardo



By Mike Hayes

Published Sep 19, 2026

50 comments

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Di Leonardo, who said he works frequently with the NYPD to rescue animals in “all sorts of cases from cockfighting to exotic animal crimes to things like this,” told Gothamist a group of about 15 activists from the Kaparos Compassion Project immediately set out from Long Island and New Jersey and arrived at the scene about two hours later.

“When we arrived on scene, birds were in horrible conditions,” he told Gothamist. “Flies all around them. They were all dehydrated, very, very weak. Many of them were dead.”

Di Leonardo said that dozens of dead chickens were found inside crates in the truck bed.

He said the NYPD told him it is looking for the person who abandoned the truck. Gothamist asked the NYPD to confirm it is conducting an investigation.

Photos from the scene shared with Gothamist show a sign affixed to the truck that reads “Kaparos To Go.” Rina Deych, a Jewish animal rights activist from Borough Park, told Gothamist that Kaparos is an ancient Jewish custom in which a live chicken is circled overhead during prayer and then slaughtered. Kaparos, which is only practiced by some ultra-Orthodox Jewish sects, typically takes place on the eve of Yom Kippur, which begins at sundown on Sunday, Sept. 20.

"It's a very small percentage of Jews," she said.

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"I'm calling the neighbors, we're going on the way right there right now. There's dead and dying chickens in a second 'Kaparos to Go' truck nearby," he said.

Deych said she and others from the Kaparos Compassion Project would be visiting a Kaparos ritual planned in Crown Heights on Saturday night. But rather than stopping the practitioners, she said, her group will be feeding the chickens before they're sacrificed.

"We cut up strips of watermelon, and we stick them through the crates, and we try to feed as many chickens as we can to give them a little relief before they go through this horrific ritual," she said.

In 2005, over 300 chickens intended for Kaparos were found crammed into wooden crates inside a vacant lot on Coney Island Avenue, the New York Post reported at the time. About 35 had drowned, and an Orthodox Jewish man was charged with animal cruelty in connection with their deaths. The remaining chickens were taken to an animal sanctuary in Upstate New York.

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criminal justice. He has written for ProPublica, CNN, HuffPost, BuzzFeed News and The Appeal...

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steeb

19 September, 2026

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**L.A. Vaught**

21 September, 2026

I think using live animals for cult practices is cruel and ought to be prohibited by the Council.

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**Frida**

20 September, 2026

Using live animals for cult practices is cruel and ought to be prohibited by the Council.

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**Moe**

19 September, 2026

Based on where the chickens were found, acc. to the NY Post, I would suspect that perp(s) are connected to the Chabad Lubavitch Hasidic sect, as some of them reside in proximity. That is the group who considers their late Rebbe to be Messiah, though he passed over thirty years ago.

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The Woodpecker!

20 September, 2026

"Undisclosed sanctuary" = Chik-fil-a loading dock after the inspectors go home.

(Edited)

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L.A.Vaught

20 September, 2026

This doesn't seem cultish at all.

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The Lone Apple🍏

20 September, 2026

Thank dog I'm an atheist.

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Heyward

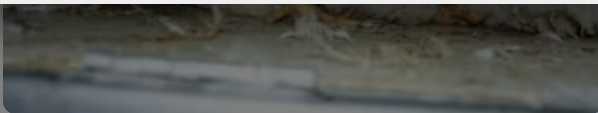
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By Liam Quigley

Published Sep 28, 2026

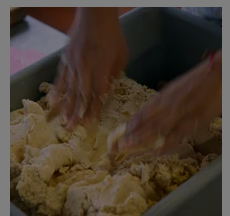
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The Garden State now requires that corn masa dough and flour made and sold in the state be fortified with folic acid.

By Arya Sundaram

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failed, a lawyer said.

tunnels since 1910

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By
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